

ALGEBRAIC NUMBER THEORY

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Fifth Semester

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Chapter 1

THE RATIONALS

July 20th.

Prerequisites for this course include Rings and Modules (tensor products, localization, etc.), Field and Galois Theory, and bits of Commutative Algebra and Algebraic Geometry.

1.1 Algebraic Extensions

The basic object of study in algebraic number theory is the field of rational numbers $\mathbb{Q}$. We recall the field inclusions $\mathbb{Q} \subset \mathbb{R} \subset \mathbb{C}$. We will be interested in the field of algebraic numbers $\overline{\mathbb{Q}} \subset \mathbb{C}$.

Definition 1.1. We say $k \subseteq L$ is a *field extension* if k and L are both fields. In this case, we say L is an extension of k and write L/k .

Let k be a field, and $k[X]$ the polynomial ring over k . Let $f(X) \in k[X]$ be a polynomial with $\deg(f) = n$, and $\langle f(X) \rangle \subseteq k[X]$ the ideal generated by $f(X)$. Now define $V := k[X]/\langle f(X) \rangle = \{g(X) + \langle f(X) \rangle \mid g(X) \in k[X]\}$. This V is a vector space over k . Moreover, $\dim_k(V) = n = \deg(f)$; let $\overline{g(X)} = g(\overline{X}) = g(X) + \langle f(X) \rangle$ denote an element in V . Using the division algorithm, we can write $g = fh + r$ with $\deg(r) < n$, and hence $\overline{g(X)} = \overline{r(X)}$. Thus, the set $\mathcal{B} = \{1, \overline{X}, \dots, \overline{X}^{n-1}\}$ is a generating set for V . It is also linearly independent, showing that $\mathcal{B}$ is a basis for V , and hence $\dim_k(V) = n$.

Theorem 1.2. Let k be a field, and $f(X) \in k[X]$ with $\deg f > 0$. There then exists a field $L \supset k$ such that $[L : k] := \dim_k L$ is finite, and $f(X)$ has a root in L .

Proof. Without the loss of generality, we may assume that $f(X)$ is irreducible over k . Write $f(X) = X^n + a_{n-1}X^{n-1} + \dots + a_0$. Consider the companion matrix of f :

$$C(f) = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & \cdots & 0 & -a_0 \\ 1 & 0 & \cdots & 0 & -a_1 \\ 0 & 1 & \cdots & 0 & -a_2 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & \cdots & 1 & -a_{n-1} \end{pmatrix} \quad (1.1)$$

This matrix may be obtained from the k -linear map $\ell_{\overline{X}} : k[X]/\langle f \rangle \rightarrow k[X]/\langle f \rangle$ defined by $\ell_{\overline{X}}(g(\overline{X})) = \overline{X}g(\overline{X})$; the matrix of $\ell_{\overline{X}}$ with respect to the basis $\mathcal{B}$ formed previously is precisely $C(f)$. Note that the minimal and characteristic polynomials of $C(f)$ are both equal to $f(X)$. Define $\alpha := C(f) \in M_n(k)$, and let $L := \{b_0 + b_1\alpha + \dots + b_{n-1}\alpha^{n-1} \mid b_i \in k\} \subseteq M_n(k)$. Then L is a ring. In fact, L is a field since any non-zero element's inverse can be computed using the division algorithm. Moreover, $f(\alpha) = 0$ and $L \supset k$.

As an alternate proof, setting $L := k[X]/\langle f \rangle$ gives a field extension of k since $\langle f \rangle$ is a maximal ideal. Moreover, $\overline{X} \in L$ is a root of $f(X)$. ■

1. Let R be a (commutative) ring, and $\{S_\lambda\}_{\lambda \in \Lambda}$ be an arbitrary collection of subrings of R . Then $\bigcap_{\lambda \in \Lambda} S_\lambda$ is also a subring of R .
2. In particular, the intersection of all subrings of R is a subring of R termed the *prime subring* of R denoted by $\mathfrak{p}_R$. It is also the image of the ring homomorphism $\mathbb{Z} \rightarrow R$ defined by $n \mapsto n \cdot 1_R$.
3. Let $R \subseteq S$ be rings, and $T \subseteq S$ be a subset. Define $R[T]$ as the intersection of all subrings of S containing R and T . It is precisely $\{f(t_1, \dots, t_r) \mid f \in R[X_1, \dots, X_r], r \geq 0, t_i \in T\}$.

If we let $k \subseteq L$ be fields, and $S \subseteq L$ be a subset, then $k[S]$ is an integral domain. We can then further define $k(S)$ as the field of fractions of $k[S]$, or

$$k(S) = \bigcap_{\substack{E \text{ field} \\ k \subseteq E \subseteq L \\ S \subseteq E}} E = \left\{ \frac{f(s_1, \dots, s_r)}{g(s_1, \dots, s_r)} \mid f, g \in k[X_1, \dots, X_r], g \neq 0, s_i \in S, r \geq 0 \right\}. \quad (1.2)$$

Thus, $k(S)$ is the smallest subfield of L containing k and S .

Definition 1.3. An element $\alpha \in \mathbb{C}$ is said to be an *algebraic number* (over $\mathbb{Q}$) if α is a root of a non-zero polynomial over $\mathbb{Q}$.

Definition 1.4. Define

$$\overline{\mathbb{Q}} := \{\alpha \in \mathbb{C} \mid \alpha \text{ is an algebraic number}\} \subseteq \mathbb{C}. \quad (1.3)$$

This is termed the *field of algebraic numbers*.

Of course, the fact that $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}$ is a field is not immediate. We prove minor results to support this claim.

Lemma 1.5. Let $\alpha \in \overline{\mathbb{Q}}$ and $m_\alpha(X)$ be the (a) non-zero minimal degree polynomial over $\mathbb{Q}$ with $m_\alpha(\alpha) = 0$. Then $m_\alpha(X)$ is irreducible over $\mathbb{Q}$.

Lemma 1.6. Let $\alpha \in \overline{\mathbb{Q}}$. Then $\mathbb{Q}[\alpha] = \mathbb{Q}(\alpha)$, and $[\mathbb{Q}(\alpha) : \mathbb{Q}]$ is finite.

The concept of algebraic numbers can be generalized to any field k . Let $k \subseteq L$ be a field extension. An element $\alpha \in L$ is said to be algebraic over k if α is a root of a non-zero polynomial over k . Here, $k[\alpha] = k(\alpha)$, and $[k(\alpha) : k] = \deg m_{\alpha(X)}$ is finite.

Lemma 1.7. Let $E \supseteq L \supseteq k$ be fields. Then $[E : k] = [E : L][L : k]$.

Proof. If one of E/L or L/k is infinite dimensional, then E/k is infinite dimensional and the equality holds. Now assume E/k is finite dimensional. Clearly, $[E : k]$ being of finite dimension implies that $[E : L]$ and $[L : k]$ are finite dimensional. Let $\{e_1, \dots, e_m\}$ be an L -basis for E , and $\{\ell_1, \dots, \ell_n\}$ be a k -basis for L . We claim that $\{e_i \ell_j \mid 1 \leq i \leq m, 1 \leq j \leq n\}$ is a k -basis for E . It is clear that this set spans E over k . To show linear independence, assume $\sum_{i,j} a_{ij} e_i \ell_j = 0$ for some $a_{ij} \in k$. Then $\sum_i (\sum_j a_{ij} \ell_j) e_i = 0$. Since $\{e_1, \dots, e_m\}$ is linearly independent over L , we have $\sum_j a_{ij} \ell_j = 0$ for each i . Since $\{\ell_1, \dots, \ell_n\}$ is linearly independent over k , we have $a_{ij} = 0$ for all i, j . Thus, the set is linearly independent over k , and hence a basis. Therefore, $[E : k] = mn = [E : L][L : k]$. ■

Definition 1.8. A field extension L/k is called an *algebraic extension* if all elements of L are algebraic over k .

Theorem 1.9. Every finite extension of a field is algebraic.

Proof. Let L/k be a finite extension. Then for any $\alpha \in L$, set the left multiplication map $\ell_\alpha : L \rightarrow L$ defined by $\ell_\alpha(x) = \alpha x$. This is a k -linear map, and hence has a characteristic polynomial $P_\alpha(X)$. By the Cayley-Hamilton theorem, $P_\alpha(\ell_\alpha) = 0$, and hence $P_\alpha(\alpha) = 0$. Thus, α is algebraic over k . ■

July 22nd.

Theorem 1.10. *Let $E \supseteq L \supseteq k$ be fields. Then E/k is algebraic if and only if both E/L and L/k are algebraic.*

Such an inclusion is termed a *tower of extensions*. To prove this theorem, we require the following lemma.

Lemma 1.11. *Let $L \supseteq k$ be a field extension, and let $\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_n \in L$ be algebraic over k . Then $k(\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_n)$ is finite dimensional, and algebraic, over k .*

A field extension $L = k(\beta)$ is called a *simple extension*. In general, if L/k is a field extension, then L/k is called a *finitely generated extension* if there exists a finite subset $S \subseteq L$ such that $L = k(S)$. Note that a finitely generated extension need not be a finite extension. For example, $\mathbb{Q}(\pi)/\mathbb{Q}$ is finitely generated but not finite.

Proof of theorem. Let us assume L/E and E/k are algebraic; let $\alpha \in E$. Then α is algebraic over L , and there exists a non-zero polynomial $g(X) \in L[X]$ such that $g(\alpha) = 0$. Write $g(X) = a_0 + a_1X + \dots + a_rX^r$ with $a_i \in L$. Now consider $k(a_0, a_1, \dots, a_r)$; here, each a_i is algebraic over k so $k(a_0, a_1, \dots, a_r)/k$ is algebraic. Consider $k(a_0, a_1, \dots, a_r)(\alpha)$; since α is algebraic over $k(a_0, a_1, \dots, a_r)$, we have $[k(a_0, a_1, \dots, a_r)(\alpha) : k(a_0, a_1, \dots, a_r)] < \infty$. Thus, $[k(a_0, a_1, \dots, a_r)(\alpha) : k]$ is finite, and hence α is algebraic over k . Since $\alpha \in E$ was arbitrary, we have that E/k is algebraic. The converse is immediate since any $\alpha \in L$ is also in E , and hence algebraic over k . ■

Example 1.12. As an exercise, show that an algebraic extension L/k is finitely generated if and only if $[L : k]$ is finite.

1.2 Number Fields

Simply put, a finite field extension of the rationals $\mathbb{Q}$ is called a *number field*. Examples include $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$, $\mathbb{Q}(\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_r)$ where α_i are algebraic over $\mathbb{Q}$. Non-examples include $\mathbb{Q}(\pi)$, $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}, \sqrt{3}, \sqrt{5}, \dots, \sqrt{p}, \dots)$ for all primes p . Recall the field of algebraic numbers:

$$\overline{\mathbb{Q}} = \{\alpha \in \mathbb{C} \mid \alpha \text{ is algebraic over } \mathbb{Q}\}. \quad (1.4)$$

It is left as an exercise to show that $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}$ is a field, and that $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}/\mathbb{Q}$ is an algebraic extension.

Definition 1.13. A field K is called *algebraically closed* if every non-constant polynomial $f(X) \in K[X]$ has a root in K . Equivalently, irreducible polynomials over K are exactly the linear polynomials.

For example, $\mathbb{C}$ is algebraically closed, but $\mathbb{R}$ is not. This is a consequence of the fundamental theorem of algebra.

Example 1.14. The field $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}$ is algebraically closed. To show this, let $f(X) \in \overline{\mathbb{Q}}[X]$ be an irreducible polynomial. By the fundamental theorem of algebra, there exists a root $\alpha \in \mathbb{C}$ of $f(X)$. So, $\mathbb{Q}(\alpha)/\mathbb{Q}$ is algebraic. But since $\mathbb{Q}/\mathbb{Q}$ is algebraic, we have that $\mathbb{Q}(\alpha)/\mathbb{Q}$ is algebraic. Thus, $\alpha \in \overline{\mathbb{Q}}$, and hence $f(X)$ has a root in $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}$.

If we define $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}^{\mathbb{R}} = \{\alpha \in \mathbb{R} \mid \alpha \text{ is algebraic over } \mathbb{Q}\}$. Clearly, $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}^{\mathbb{R}}$ is algebraic. Consider $i \in \mathbb{C}$; i is algebraic over $\mathbb{Q}$ but $i \notin \mathbb{R}$, so $i \notin \overline{\mathbb{Q}}^{\mathbb{R}}$. Thus, the minimal polynomial of i over $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}^{\mathbb{R}}$ is $X^2 + 1$, which is irreducible over $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}^{\mathbb{R}}$. Hence, $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}^{\mathbb{R}}$ is not algebraically closed.

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